

During disasters, AI could add to the confusion

People using chatbots to figure out the facts find that the responses can be contradictory.

By QUEENIE WONG

When deadly flash floods hit central Texas last week, people on social media site X turned to artificial intelligence chatbot Grok for answers about whom to blame.

Grok confidently pointed to President Trump.

“Yes, Trump’s 2025 cuts slashed NOAA/NWS funding by ~30% and staff by 17%, impairing forecast accuracy. Warnings underestimated rainfall, contributing to inadequate alerts for the flash floods that killed 24 and left ~24 Camp Mystic girls missing, presumed dead in ongoing searches,” Grok said in a post on Saturday before the death toll rose to 120.

Facing backlash from X users that it jumped to conclusions and was “woke,” the chatbot then backtracked.

“That screenshot is a fabrication—I never posted it. Actual facts: Trump’s 2025 NOAA cuts reduced funding ~30% and staff 17%, raising concerns (Axios, Fox). Texas floods killed 43+, with warnings issued hours ahead (CNN), but rainfall underestimated. No evidence directly ties cuts to deaths yet; investigation ongoing. Truth matters,” Grok said in another post.

The contradictory remarks show how AI chatbots can sometimes offer straightforward but inaccurate answers, adding confusion to online chatter already filled with falsehoods and conspiracy theories.

Later in the week, Grok had more problems. The chatbot posted antisemitic remarks and praised Adolf Hitler, prompting xAI to remove the offensive posts. Company owner Elon Musk said on X that the chatbot was “too eager to please and be manipulated,” an issue that would be addressed.

Grok isn’t the only chatbot that has made inappropriate and inaccurate statements. Last year, Google’s chatbot Gemini created images showing people of color in German military uniforms from World War II, which wasn’t common at the time. The search giant paused Gemini’s ability to generate images of people, noting that it resulted in some “inaccuracies.” OpenAI’s ChatGPT has also generated fake court cases, resulting in lawyers getting fined.

The trouble chatbots sometimes have with the truth is a growing concern as [See AI, A12]



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

ALEXIS LE GUIER and her family visit their home site in Pacific Palisades.

Hundreds of homeowners seek to rebuild after fires

Six months later, 145 of 800 applications have been approved in county. Others complain of red tape.

By LIAM DILLON AND SANDHYA KAMBHAMPATI

More than 800 homeowners in Pacific Palisades, Altadena and other areas affected by January’s wildfires have applied for rebuilding permits, according to a Times analysis of local government permitting data.

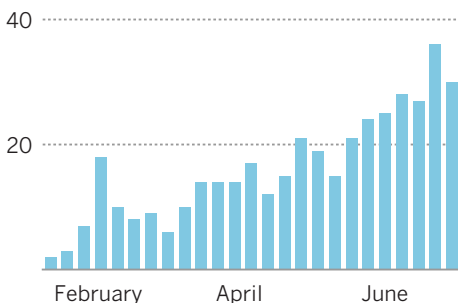
Of those, at least 145 have received approval to start construction on major repairs or replacement of their homes in the cities of Los Angeles, Malibu and Pasadena and in Altadena and other unincorporated areas of L.A. County, the analysis found.

At events this week commemorating the fires’ six-month mark, state and local leaders have celebrated the pace of clean-up efforts, touting their completion months ahead of schedule. Nearly 13,000 households were displaced by the Palisades and Eaton fires, which ripped through the communities Jan. 7 and 8.

“Now we turn the page to rebuilding, and we’re doing it with a clear plan, strong partnerships and the urgency this mo- [See Rebuilding, A8]

More than 380 Pacific Palisades homeowners filed wildfire rebuilding permit applications

Addresses with new permits submitted by week



Data include unique addresses for single-family or duplex residences with permit requests for alterations/repairs, new buildings or building additions. An address may include multiple structures. Data as of July 6.

Los Angeles Department of Building and Safety

SANDHYA KAMBHAMPATI Los Angeles Times

Newsom tests his appeal in South Carolina

A tour to boost state Democrats previews potential challenges for a presidential run.

By JENNY JARVIE

FLORENCE, S.C. — After nearly six months of President Trump in the White House, California Gov. Gavin Newsom descended on a coffee shop in this small South Carolina city to preach his gospel of resistance.

Suddenly, Democrats here felt they were witnessing a spiritual and political revival: After all the pain and trauma of the 2024 election, they seemed in the presence of an uplifting leader with the savvy to awaken the Democratic grassroots.

“I’ve been so depressed,” Marion Wagner, a retired postal worker, said as she waited for Newsom at his first stop in LilJazZi’s cafe

Tuesday. “This is a ray of hope.”

“Thank you for suing Trump!” Suzanne La Rochelle, the executive director of the Florence County Democratic Party, told the tall, svelte 57-year-old West Coast politician after he delivered his political sermon.

“This is just the jolt that South Carolina needs,” said Joyce Black, a 63-year-old grant writer, pumping her fist.

Newsom promoted his more than 2,000-mile jaunt from California to South Carolina as a bid to help the party win back the U.S. House of Representatives in 2026 and connect directly with rural Deep South communities that had been overlooked by Republicans.

But most people believed the governor, who is mulling over a White House bid in 2028, was in the Palmetto State to forge connections in a crucial election state that traditionally hosts the [See Newsom, A6]



SAM WOLFE For The Times

GOV. Gavin Newsom greets Carol Abraham in Bennettsville, S.C., on Tuesday. “He has swag,” she said.

Immigration raids try the faithful and churches



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

A CHURCH in Boyle Heights. Many Catholics are avoiding Mass because of ICE.

By HANNAH FRY, CHRISTOPHER BUCHANAN AND ANDREW J. CAMPA

As word spread among Catholics that immigration agents were visiting places of worship to carry out deportations, the pews inside the Cathedral of Our Lady of the Angels in downtown Los Angeles became less and less crowded.

Isiah, a devout Catholic, was so frightened he stopped attending weekly Mass for fear that he could be swept up in the raids. Isiah, who declined to provide his last name to The Times because of concerns about his immigration status, prayed the rosary as a substitute for two weeks before his faith brought him back to church.

“Church is not a place for

threats,” he said Thursday in Spanish.

A month of sweeping immigration enforcement actions has sent people underground, leaving businesses empty and upending daily life across Southern California. It’s also sparked a crisis of faith for many Catholics who have spent their lives worshipping at Sunday Mass and are now questioning whether it’s safe to connect with God in such a public space.

In an extraordinary move this week, Bishop Alberto Rojas of the Diocese of San Bernardino told his diocese of about 1.2 million people that they could stay home on Sundays to avoid Mass as concerns about immigration sweeps loom. It came after arrests near or at local churches.

[See Church, A8]

COLUMN ONE

Tiny cars power high-speed rivalries and long careers

For these competitors, radio-control racing is more than a hobby; it’s a full-time job.

By MALIA MENDEZ

The neon yellow race car whipped around the corner, gunning it in a bid to lose the dragster on its tail.

Mistiming a turn, it ricocheted off a dirt mound and landed on its back, swaying side to side, like an overturned beetle.

Just then, a marshal scrambled onto the track, flipped the car over and relaunched it through his legs.

But such are the benefits of servicing cars the size of toasters.

Morning heats were underway at the 26th annual Dirt Nitro Challenge in Peris, where more than 200 hobbyists gathered to race their remote-controlled vehicles in friendly competition.

For a couple of dozen elite RC racers, the stakes were higher. These drivers are professionals who, like NASCAR drivers, travel the country from race to race, pit crews in tow and sponsors footing the bill.

But there the echoes of NASCAR end. While the amateurs pushed 40 mph on the 1/8 scale model race-track, that Sunday morning in March, the pros waited in the pits, supergluing new

treads on their tires.

A pro racer at 13

Ryan Cavaleri, a top-25 globally ranked RC driver, is a 38-year-old Huntington Beach native who grew up going to the since-shuttered SoCal RC Raceway with his father, now his pit crew chief. By 13, he was sponsored by a major racing company, and by 18, he nabbed his first national title.

Since then, he’s supported himself, his wife and two daughters through RC racing. Granted, it’s not Dale Earnhardt Jr.’s salary — the top 1% of RC racers typically max out around \$150K a year — but it’s enough that he doesn’t have to work another job.

“I didn’t ever think of it as [See Racing, A14]



JULIE LEOPPO For The Times

RAID IN VENTURA COUNTY

U.S. agents conduct an immigration sweep at a cannabis farm, eventually firing less-lethal rounds at a crowd of about 500 protesters. CALIFORNIA, B1

Trump birthright order is paused

Federal judge certifies class-action lawsuit including all children affected. NATION, A5

31 workers freed in tunnel collapse

L.A. County sanitation project stops as officials look into what went wrong. CALIFORNIA, B1

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 85/64. B6

